

I OBJECT!

Your contract will specify a fateful day by which you must submit an inspection objection notice to the seller in which you address any major issues found during the inspection. Usually, you either request that the seller make repairs to the home or provide a credit at closing to cover the cost of those repairs.

There is a lot of confusion among first-time home buyers regarding the home inspection and inspection report. Some people like to think that the seller will simply fix every issue that pops up. By no means are they required to accept your request, since this is one of those contractual checkpoints that works as an escape hatch for both buyer and seller. While the buyer can back out if they find a horrible case of mold/radon/asbestos in the basement, the seller can also refuse an overdone inspection objection.

Instead, ask your agent for guidance regarding what you should ask the seller to repair and what you should be prepared to handle yourself. No home is perfect, and you shouldn't expect yours to be either. The point of the inspection isn't to get a spotless home—the point is to not be surprised with a massive repair unless you're compensated with a price reduction.

Now that we've mentioned your two options—either the seller makes repairs or you get a credit at closing—you might be wondering which is the better choice. Though it may be tempting to request the repairs and get them off your hands, we actually recommend that you request a credit at closing.

“But then,” you sigh, “I have to hire people and fix things.”

True, it's a little more work. However, not only will the credit at closing reduce your total closing costs, but the seller is incentivized to have the repairs performed at the lowest possible price. They don't want to spend wads of cash on a repair for a home they're no longer going to live in, and you don't want to put the fate of your house (and your health, if we're talking about mold, asbestos, lead paint, or radon) in their hands. If you aren't comfortable with waiting for repairs—or if a repair is required for the sale to close per your lender—you can still work this into the inspection objection. Simply require the seller to use a certain company to perform the work, one that you've vetted on your own.

When putting together the inspection objection notice, make sure you and your agent are specific and direct. You don't want any ambiguity in